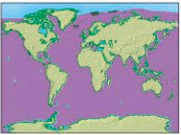


Orcinus orca

Killer whale



Length 32½ ft (Up to 9.8 m)
Weight Up to 65 tons (66 tonnes)
Social unit Group
Status Data deficient

Location Worldwide



Distinctive black-and-white markings make the killer whale—which is also commonly known as the orca—the most easily recognized of the toothed whales and dolphins. It is a highly social whale, living in long-lasting family groups called pods, which consist of adult males and females, and calves of various ages. Pods typically number up to 30 individuals, but groups of as many as 150 whales occur when pods come together to form superpods. Pods are matriarchal and both male and female calves tend to stay with their mother for life. When the young reproduce, their offspring remain to build up multigenerational groupings around the original mother. Generally, the killer whale’s diet is as diverse as its hunting

techniques. Fish, ranging from herring to great white sharks, and marine mammals, including whales and seals, are taken, as well as turtles and birds. Resident killer whales of the northwestern coast of North America feed almost exclusively on salmon, whereas the transient killer whales in the same area hunt marine mammals, and do not consume fish. Killer whales from the Norwegian fjords are known to consume herring. Elsewhere, there are other dietary preferences. This has led to different hunting techniques. Despite its name, the killer whale is approachable and very inquisitive. It has a variety of elaborate surface habits, including spy hopping (rising slowly vertically, until its head is above the water), tail and flipper slapping, and breaching.



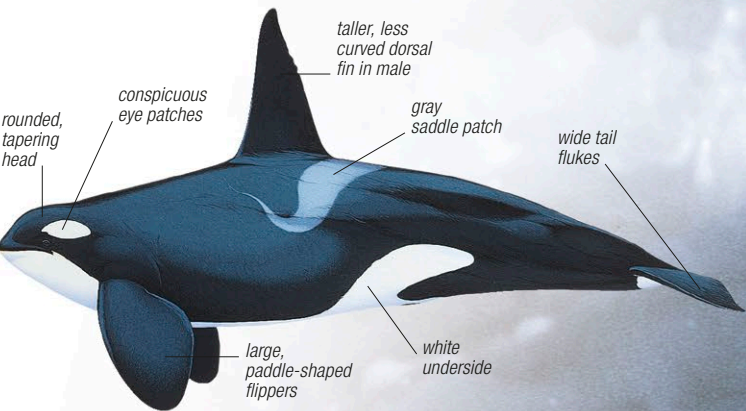
PARENTAL CARE

The whole pod may provide parental care, but a newborn calf stays closest to its mother—a bond that will remain strong for the rest of its life.



POD FORMATIONS

Pods may travel in tight formations, with the females and calves at the center, and the males on the fringes, or spread across distances of up to 2½ mile (1 km). They communicate using sets of highly distinctive cries and screams, which also act as social signals that reinforce group identity.



BUILT FOR HUNTING

The killer whale has a powerfully built, stocky body ideally suited to hunting. The broad tail flukes help propel the whale at high speeds, and the dorsal fin—which reaches up to 6 ft (1.8 m) in males—and paddlike flippers provide stability. Underwater, its markings have the effect of camouflaging the whale from above and below.